

THE WORLD BIBLE: AMERICA & HOLLYWOOD, UP TO DAY ONE

The real-world story's world, as it stands on Monday, March 12, 2007

STATUS:  LOCKED as world canon.  The real-world story has started (Chapter One opens April 28, 2006, in this world).

How to read this document. Our world is **the real world**, with its real history, real people, real headlines and real prices. **Three pebbles** have been dropped into it. Everything unique about this world is **a ripple from one of those three pebbles**. If something isn't a ripple, it happened exactly the way it happened in real life.

0. THE THREE PEBBLES

#	The pebble	Where it lands
1	Marvel never sold a single film right. Avi Arad founded Marvel Studios in 1996 so the company would own its movies, and no Marvel character has ever appeared in a theatrical film.	Hollywood's whole idea of what a comic-book movie is
2	Donohue Entertainment exists. Founded in 1966 by Victor Donohue in a converted Crenshaw laundromat, it's the largest Black-owned entertainment company in America.	Los Angeles, the music business, television, and every room the Bullock kids walk into
3	The Ensemble exists. Ten fictional actors, plus the Donohue–Bullock family, and every show, song and film they've ever made.	American pop culture from 1986 to 2007

Everything else is real. George W. Bush is president. The Iraq War is in its fifth year. Hurricane Katrina happened. YouTube, MySpace and the iPod happened. The only question this bible answers is **what the pebbles changed**.

1. THE COUNTRY: THE UNITED STATES ON DAY ONE

The mood: "Something is about to break"

America in March 2007 feels like **a room right before the power goes out**. Nothing has collapsed yet, but everyone can hear the building creak.

Area	Where things stand on Monday, March 12, 2007 (real history)
Politics	President George W. Bush , second term, approval in the low 30s. On January 4 , Democrats took both houses of Congress and Nancy Pelosi became the first woman Speaker of the House . On January 10 , Bush announced the "surge" of more than 20,000 more troops to Iraq.
The 2008 race	Hillary Clinton announced on January 20 . A first-term Illinois senator, Barack Obama , announced on the steps of the Old State Capitol in Springfield on Saturday, February 10, 2007 .
The economy	The Dow is around 12,300 . On February 27 it fell 416 points in one day. Housing prices have stopped rising. This week , subprime lender New Century Financial is collapsing (the NYSE halts its stock on March 13 ; bankruptcy follows April 2). Almost nobody outside Wall Street knows the words "subprime mortgage" yet.
Technology	On January 9 , Steve Jobs announced the iPhone (on sale June 29). MySpace is the biggest social network in the country. Facebook opened to everyone on September 26, 2006. Google bought YouTube for \$1.65 billion in October 2006. Twitter is having its breakout moment at SXSW in Austin, this very week (March 9–13).
Television	<i>American Idol</i> season 6 is at its peak (Sanjaya is still on). <i>Heroes</i> (NBC) is the hottest new show. <i>The Sopranos</i> begins its final season on April 8. <i>Grey's Anatomy</i> , <i>Lost</i> , 24.
The aftermath	Hurricane Katrina hit on August 29, 2005 . Nineteen months later, New Orleans is still half-empty .
Prices	Gas $\approx$ \$2.55/gal · the average movie ticket is \$6.88 (2007) · the federal minimum wage is \$5.15 (it goes up to \$5.85 on July 24, 2007) · a first-class stamp is 39¢

Where the pebbles touch the country

Real event	The ripple
Katrina, August 29, 2005	It hit on Elxa Bullock's 25th birthday . She canceled her party and turned that night's <i>Elxa After Dark</i> into a live six-hour telethon on D1 (see Section 4). It raised \$31 million . Joan Donohue , born in New Orleans' Seventh Ward, has since spent \$40 million of family money rebuilding 212 homes there through the Mercer Homes project, named for her father. She goes back every month and never lets it be filmed.
Obama's announcement, February 10, 2007	The same day was Amond Baker's 25th birthday and Robert Bullock's 48th . Victor Donohue, a South Side Chicago man, gave to Obama's 2004 Senate race. He watched the announcement at the birthday lunch and told the table: <i>"That boy's gonna be president, and none of you believe me."</i> Amond, blowing out candles, didn't hear him.
The iPhone, January 9, 2007	Marc-Anthony Bullock bought Apple stock in 1998 at about \$13 a share , when the analysts had written Apple off. After two stock splits, each share he bought is now worth about \$350 , roughly 27 times what he paid. He hasn't sold one.
The Google IPO, August 2004	Marc bought in at \$85 . On Day One it trades around \$450 .
The federal minimum wage rise, July 24, 2007	It happens on Tyrese Avery's 26th birthday . The Averys (his fans) will spend that day raising money for fast-food workers. Tyrese will match every dollar.

2. THE BIG RIPPLE: A WORLD WITHOUT MARVEL MOVIES

The missing films

In our world, none of these films were ever made. In real history they grossed about **\$2 billion in North America**, and more than twice that worldwide.

Missing film	Real release	What happened here instead
<i>Howard the Duck</i>	1986	Nothing. Marvel has never had a movie, not even a bad one.
<i>Blade</i>	1998	Nobody proved an R-rated Black superhero could open.
<i>X-Men</i>	2000	Hugh Jackman is a Tony-winning Broadway star (<i>The Boy from Oz</i> , 2004) and "the guy from <i>Kate & Leopold</i> ." Nobody has ever called him Wolverine.
<i>Spider-Man / Spider-Man 2</i>	2002 / 2004	Sony never had its biggest franchise. Its 2002 slot went to nothing that anyone remembers. Sam Raimi is still, to Hollywood, "the <i>Evil Dead</i> guy."
<i>Daredevil, X2, Hulk</i>	2003	The only live-action Hulk ever made is still Bill Bixby and Lou Ferrigno on CBS (1977–82). That's the comparison Amond Baker is about to face.
<i>The Punisher, Blade: Trinity</i>	2004	—
<i>Elektra, Fantastic Four</i>	2005	—
<i>X-Men: The Last Stand</i>	2006	—
<i>Ghost Rider</i>	February 16, 2007	Presidents' Day weekend 2007 went to other films.
<i>Spider-Man 3</i>	May 4, 2007	The biggest hole of all (see Section 6).
<i>Fantastic Four: Rise of the Silver Surfer</i>	June 15, 2007	—

What Marvel's characters have been in this world:

- **Comics, since 1939 (Timely), 1961 (Marvel).**
- **Saturday-morning cartoons.** * **An entire generation grew up on X-Men: The Animated Series (1992–97) and Spider-Man (1994–98) on Fox Kids, produced by Marvel's own animation arm.** * **In this world, that's the only place kids have ever seen Marvel heroes move.**
- **Old TV:** *The Incredible Hulk* (1977–82), a 1977 *Spider-Man* series, two 1979 *Captain America* TV movies, and the 1998 TV movie *Nick Fury: Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D.* with David Hasselhoff, which fans bring up when they want to feel pain.
- **Toys and video games.** ToyBiz merged with Marvel in 1998 and kept the lights on.
- **Stan Lee is the most famous comic-book creator alive**, but he has **never had a movie cameo**, because there has never been a movie. In 2006 he hosted *Who Wants to Be a Superhero?* on the Sci Fi Channel (real). To most Americans he's "**the Excelsior guy.**"

Hollywood's conventional wisdom: "THE CAPE CURSE"

Without *Blade*, *X-Men* and *Spider-Man* to prove otherwise, **every studio in town believes superhero movies are box-office poison.** The evidence, as any executive will list it for you:

The case against capes	Year	The lesson Hollywood took
<i>Batman & Robin</i>	1997	"Nipples on the Batsuit. The genre is a joke."
<i>Steel</i> (Shaquille O'Neal)	1997	"\$1.7 million. Black superheroes don't sell."
<i>Catwoman</i> (Halle Berry)	2004	"Proof. Again."
<i>Superman Returns</i>	2006	"A \$200 million-plus budget and about \$200 million domestic. Even Superman can't fly anymore."

The evidence the industry explains away:

| Hit | Year | The excuse |

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| *Batman Begins* (\$205M domestic) | 2005 | "That's a Christopher Nolan crime movie. It worked because it pretended not to be a comic-book film." |

| *The Meteor Man*, *Blankman* | 1993, 1994 | "Comedies. Don't count." (They also didn't make money.) |

| *Spawn* (\$55M domestic, a Black lead) | 1997 | Almost nobody in the industry remembers it did fine. |

| *Sin City*, *V for Vendetta*, *Hellboy* | 2004–06 | "Graphic novels. Auteur projects. Different thing." |

| *300* (\$70.9M opening, a March record) | **Friday, March 9, 2007** | **Three days before Day One.** Warner Bros. is calling it "a war movie." Nobody in the trades uses the word "comic." **Kevin Feige saw it twice that weekend**, and didn't say a word to anyone. |

So on Day One, Marvel Studios isn't just making its first movie. It's betting \$140 million against the one thing all of Hollywood agrees on.

The fans

- **Comic fandom is a subculture that believes Hollywood hates it.** Its homes are **SuperHeroHype**, **Ain't It Cool News**, **Comic Book Resources** and **Newsarama**.
- **San Diego Comic-Con** (July 26–29, 2007, around 125,000 people) is still mostly about **comics, TV and sci-fi**. **Hall H has never seen a Marvel movie panel.**
- **The fans have waited their whole lives** for a real Marvel movie. They're **thrilled, terrified and deeply suspicious** of anything that changes the comics. **Every casting announcement is a war** on the forums.
- The recurring forum voices we already know: **XxWolverineXx** (a purist skeptic whose screen name is the name of a hero **who has never been in a movie**), **ExcelsiorFaithful**, **PepperPottsFanClub**.

3. HOLLYWOOD ON DAY ONE: THE MAP

The six majors (real)

Studio	Its state in March 2007	The ripple
Warner Bros.	<i>Harry Potter</i> , <i>Batman Begins</i> , and this weekend 300 . The strongest studio in town.	Owns the only living superhero film franchise , and DC's whole library . Its executives quietly laugh at Marvel .
Walt Disney	Bob Iger has been CEO since October 2005. Bought Pixar for \$7.4 billion (2006). <i>Pirates of the Caribbean</i> .	Iger is watching Marvel . Nobody knows it yet .
Paramount	Chairman Brad Grey . Bought DreamWorks (2006). Split publicly with Tom Cruise (August 2006).	Distributes Marvel's films for about an 8% fee and has no creative control . Around the lot, the deal is known as " Brad's comic-book bet ."
Universal	<i>The Bourne</i> films	—
20th Century Fox	<i>Ice Age</i> , <i>Night at the Museum</i>	No X-Men . Its summer 2000 and 2003 tentpoles went to films nobody remembers.
Sony / Columbia	<i>The Da Vinci Code</i> , <i>Casino Royale</i> (with MGM)	The studio with the hole in its heart . In real history, <i>Spider-Man</i> made Sony about \$2.5 billion. Here, Sony spent the 2000s trying to buy, build or steal a franchise , and it's ready to overpay for one.

The mini-majors: Lionsgate (*Saw*), New Line (*The Lord of the Rings*), The Weinstein Company (launched 2005), MGM (struggling), DreamWorks (now under Paramount).

The seventh sister: DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT

The trades have a nickname for it: "**the seventh sister**." It's **not a major**, but **every major has tried to buy it**, and **it has turned every one of them down**. In the whole industry **only two companies have famously refused to sell what they own: Donohue Entertainment and Marvel**. (Victor Donohue and Avi Arad have met exactly once. They got along *very* well.)

Division	Founded	What it is in 2007
Donohue Records	1966 , in a converted laundromat at Crenshaw & 43rd	The original. A soul, R&B and hip-hop catalog of more than 9,000 masters, all owned outright.
Donohue Pictures	1972	About six films a year: family dramas, comedies, prestige pictures. Robert Bullock's <i>Harbor Street</i> (1994) was its first Oscar nominee for Best Director.
The Crenshaw Lot	1972	31 acres in South Los Angeles: nine soundstages , a backlot "Main Street," and the original laundromat, kept as a museum. During the 1992 riots , Victor kept the gates open, paid every employee , and fed the neighborhood from the commissary for six days. Nobody touched the lot.
Donohue Television	1979	Sitcoms and dramas for the networks, including <i>The Mercers</i> (ABC, 1986–93).
Donohue Talent	1983	A boutique talent management company. Natasha Bullock manages her own children through it. It's feared across town.
D1	1994	A Black-owned cable network with 72 million homes. BET was sold to Viacom in 2001; D1 has never been sold. Its flagship is <i>Elva After Dark</i> . Slogan: " <i>Ours.</i> "
The Donohue Foundation	1988	Scholarships, Mercer Homes (New Orleans), and the Crenshaw Film Academy , a free film school for South L.A. teenagers.

House rule, painted over the commissary door: "*Own the masters. Own the land. Own the name.*"

Net worth: about **\$4.1 billion** (Victor, 2007).

The social event of Hollywood's year: Thanksgiving at the Donohue estate in View Park. **Invitations are handwritten by Joan.** Getting one means you've made it. **Losing one** is industry news.

The unwritten rules of Hollywood, 2007

In the Hollywood of 2007, these are "facts" that everyone knows. **Every member of the Ensemble is about to break one of them.**

The rule	Who breaks it
"Child stars don't grow up."	Marc-Anthony, Esther, Elxa
"Sidekicks don't become leads."	Amond, Tayia
"Singers can't act."	Tyrese
"Broadway doesn't translate to film."	Grace, Harmony
"You're the science guy."	Tyler
"Not the type."	Arianna
"Black leads don't sell overseas."	All of them
"Capes are box-office poison."	Marvel
"A comic-book company can't make movies."	Kevin Feige

Black Hollywood in 2007 (real, with one addition)

- **Two weeks before Day One**, at the 79th Academy Awards (**February 25, 2007**), **Forest Whitaker** won Best Actor (*The Last King of Scotland*) and **Jennifer Hudson** won Best Supporting Actress (*Dreamgirls*). **Eddie Murphy** was nominated too. The industry calls it "**a big night**" and then goes back to making the same decisions.
- **Will Smith is the biggest movie star in the world** (*The Pursuit of Happyness*, 2006). **Denzel Washington** is an institution. **Tyler Perry** is building his own studio in Atlanta.
- **The executive suites are still almost entirely white**. The "**urban**" **budget ceiling** is real. **The overseas-box-office excuse** kills Black-led projects every week.
- **The addition: Donohue Entertainment**, where **all of that is different**, and everyone in town knows it.

Power and money

- **2006 domestic box office: about \$9.2 billion**. DVD sales are at their **all-time peak**. The home-video money pays for Hollywood.
- **The "threequel summer" of 2007** is coming: *Shrek the Third* (May 18), *Pirates of the Caribbean: At World's End* (May 25), *Ocean's Thirteen*, *Rush Hour 3*, *The Bourne Ultimatum*. **One threequel is missing: Spider-Man 3**.
- **The storm on the horizon**: the Writers Guild's contract **expires October 31, 2007**. Everyone in town knows **a strike is coming**. It starts **November 5, 2007**.

The trades and the press (real)

Variety · The Hollywood Reporter · Deadline Hollywood Daily (Nikki Finke, since 2006, **the most feared blog in town**) · TMZ (since 2005) · Perez Hilton · *Entertainment Tonight* · *Access Hollywood* · Ain't It Cool News · SuperHeroHype · CBR · Newsarama

The fictional additions to the media world

Outlet	What it is
<i>Elxa After Dark</i> (D1, 2002–present)	The most talked-about late-night fashion and celebrity show on cable. Everyone's publicist wants them on it and dreads it at the same time.
<i>The Velvet Rope</i> (blog, 2005–present)	An anonymous gossip blogger, "Velvet," who's obsessed with the Donohue–Bullock family. Right about 70% of the time. Nobody knows who Velvet is.
Flashbulb Photo Agency	The paparazzi outfit that's followed the Bullock kids since Brainiac . Its founder shot the famous 2005 photo of Grace Bullock being held back by two bodyguards on Robertson Boulevard.
Pinnacle Artists Agency (fictional, one of the six biggest in town)	Marc-Anthony's agency since he was five. His agent, Barry Kessler, 58, loves him and has sent him 11 comedies in 14 months . He found out about the Iron Man audition from Natasha .

4. THE POP-CULTURE ALMANAC (what exists in this world)

Everything below **happened in this world**, and everyone knows it. It's **the archive footage** of our mockumentary.

Television

Show	Network	Years	Who
<i>The Mercers</i>	ABC (Donohue Television)	1986–93	Elxa Bullock (child star), directed by Joan Donohue
<i>SPLAT!</i>	Nickelodeon	1991–95	Marc-Anthony , Amond , Tayia (kids' sketch comedy; the green slime cannon was Marc's idea)
<i>Brainiac</i>	Disney Channel	1995–99	Marc-Anthony (Marcus Hayes), Tayia (Keisha Grant), Amond (the roommate). The network's top show.
<i>The Marc Bullock Show</i>	Nickelodeon	2000–03	Marc-Anthony , head writer at 18
<i>Crime Lab: Baltimore</i>	CBS	2002–06	Tyler Chapman (Dr. Wendell Pryce, the lab tech)
<i>Elxa After Dark</i>	D1	2002–present	Elxa Bullock (Daytime Emmy, 2005)
<i>Two Doors Down</i>	NBC	2005–present	Tayia Boyd (the best friend)
<i>Baker's Dozen</i>	UPN	2005–06	Amond Baker (canceled when UPN folded into The CW)
<i>Unsupervised</i>	HBO (stand-up special)	2006	Marc-Anthony , and a parents'-group boycott

Film

Film	Year	Who	Result
<i>Blue Hour</i>	1987	Natasha Donohue	Her signature role
<i>Sunny</i>	1988	Esther Smilley , age 5	\$140M ; America's little sweetheart
<i>Sunny Goes to Washington</i>	1990	Esther	A hit
<i>Sugar Hill Sweetheart</i>	1992	Esther	Golden Globe nomination at 9
<i>The Kid Who Stole Christmas</i>	1992	Esther and Marc-Anthony	A Disney holiday classic that still plays every December
<i>Harbor Street</i>	1994	Directed by Robert Bullock	Oscar nomination, Best Director
<i>Big Mouth</i>	1997	Marc-Anthony	\$118M
<i>Paper Wings</i>	1998	Elxa , age 17	Golden Globe nomination
<i>Starlight</i>	2003	Tyrese Avery	"A two-hour music video"
<i>Magnolia Falls</i>	2003	Esther	Audiences laughed at the trailer
<i>Pledge Week</i>	2004	Marc-Anthony	\$96M, R-rated
<i>Fast Lane</i>	2005	Tyrese	\$38M: a flop
<i>Loose Change</i>	2005	Esther (rom-com)	"We can't see past the dimples." It's constantly confused with the 9/11 conspiracy documentary of the same name , which Esther finds funnier than anyone.
<i>The Long Way Home</i>	2005	Marc-Anthony writes, directs and stars	Sundance Special Jury Prize. \$4.2M.
<i>Floor Work</i>	2006	Harmony Divine	\$61M surprise hit

Music

Record	Year	Who
<i>"Stand Tall"</i>	1998	Tyrese Avery , No. 1 in 23 countries
<i>Late Bloomer</i>	2000	Marc-Anthony : platinum, Grammy nomination for Best New Artist
<i>Quiet Storm</i>	2003	Amond Baker : good reviews, 180,000 copies
Tyler Chapman & The Colony	2001–present	D.C. neo-soul, one Grammy nomination
Tyrese Avery's catalog	1998–2006	Four albums, more than 45 million sold, five Grammys

Broadway

Show	Year	Who
<i>The Lion King</i>	1997	Grace Bullock , age 13, as Young Nala
<i>Sweet Georgia Brown</i> (revival)	2004	Grace : Tony Award, Best Actress in a Musical, at 20
<i>Harlem Nocturne</i>	2005	Harmony Divine : Tony Award, Best Featured Actress in a Musical

5. MARVEL STUDIOS ON DAY ONE

The building	9242 Beverly Blvd, Beverly Hills, on the floor above a Mercedes-Benz dealership. The lobby smells like new-car leather. Test drives sometimes interrupt meetings.
Staff	Fewer than 60 people. Most of them have never worked on a movie.
The money	\$525 million from Merrill Lynch (September 2005), secured by the film rights to ten characters. If <i>Iron Man</i> fails, the bank could end up owning Captain America.
The partner	Paramount (distribution only)
The leadership	David Maisel (Chairman) · Kevin Feige, 33, President of Production as of today · Avi Arad, founder, leaving May 31
The slate (public)	<i>Iron Man</i> (May 2, 2008) and <i>The Incredible Hulk</i> (June 13, 2008)
The slate (secret)	29 films. Twelve years. One story. Known only to Project Bullpen.
Today	<i>Iron Man</i> begins principal photography. Marc-Anthony Bullock, 25, in a 90-pound practical Mark I suit.
What the town thinks	"Marvel bet \$140 million on the Brainiac kid."

Marvel's long winter (1996–2005)

- **December 1996:** Marvel files for bankruptcy (real).
- **1996:** Avi Arad founds **Marvel Studios** with one rule: **never sell a film right**. Every studio in town calls with offers for **Spider-Man, the X-Men, the Fantastic Four and Blade**. Every offer is turned down. In the trades, Arad is called "*the man who said no to \$100 million.*"
- **1998:** ToyBiz merges with Marvel (real). The toys and the cartoons **keep the company alive**.
- **2000:** Kevin Feige joins Marvel Studios, a company with **no movies** and no plans to make any. He reads everything, keeps notes on all of it, and starts building a plan on paper.
- **September 6, 2005:** Merrill Lynch. Marvel will finance its own films.
- **September 29, 2006:** Marc-Anthony Bullock is cast as Tony Stark. SuperHeroHype's servers crash.
- **Friday, March 9, 2007:** *300* opens to \$70.9M. Feige sees it twice.
- **Monday, March 12, 2007:** Day One.

6. THE HORIZON: THE KNOWN CALENDAR AFTER DAY ONE

(What the world expects to happen next. Anything marked real is fixed.)

Date	Event
Thursday, April 12, 2007	Amond Baker is announced as Bruce Banner. It's also Grace Bullock's 23rd birthday .
April 17, 2007	Joan Donohue turns 69
Friday, May 4, 2007	The first Friday in May has no Spider-Man. In this world, the date belongs to <i>Meridian</i> , Sony's \$250 million original sci-fi epic, the studio's attempt to finally build a franchise of its own. Its fate is part of the story , and it will shape how the town sees <i>Iron Man</i> .
May 30, 2007	Victor Donohue turns 71
May 31, 2007	Avi Arad leaves Marvel Studios
June 2, 2007	Natasha Bullock turns 46, and Kevin Feige turns 34 on the same day .
June 29, 2007	The iPhone goes on sale (real)
July 3, 2007	<i>Transformers</i> opens (real)
July 24, 2007	Tyrese Avery turns 26, and the minimum wage rises (real)
July 26–29, 2007	San Diego Comic-Con, with no Marvel movie panel. Yet.
November 5, 2007	The writers' strike begins (real)
Friday, May 2, 2008	<i>Iron Man</i> .

CHECKLIST

- [x] The three pebbles (what's different, and why) · [x] The country on Day One, with real history and where the pebbles touch it · [x] A world without Marvel movies · [x] The Cape Curse · [x] The fans · [x] Hollywood's studios and power map · [x] Donohue Entertainment · [x] The unwritten rules each character breaks · [x] Black Hollywood in 2007 · [x] Real and fictional media · [x] The pop-culture almanac · [x] Marvel Studios on Day One · [x] The horizon

✓ The story has started: see [Chapter One](#).